

Evaluating Dietary Advice

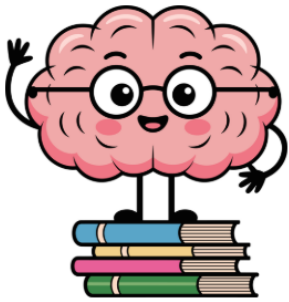
Dietary Advice

Dietary advice seems to be everywhere these days - we get it from friends, family, doctors, psychologists, influencers, personal trainers, nutritionists... and strangers! There's information online, on social media, in magazines, books, and on the TV.

With all of that unvetted information floating around, it can be difficult to figure out what's actually accurate, and to distinguish the helpful advice from the unhelpful. Often advice from one source totally contradicts advice from another! While it may be well-intentioned, not everyone is necessarily appropriately qualified or well-informed. This can be confusing as we try to make sense of mixed messages about

what we're eating. It is also potentially dangerous to make dietary changes based on information that is not reliable, factual, or tailored to our individual needs.

By checking the advice we receive more carefully, we can reduce the confusion and risks, and begin to take a more helpful, balanced, and critical stance.



Searching for Advice

Often people interested in diets search for information themselves, usually on the internet. The way we search for advice can influence the sort of information we find. If we are concerned about the impact on our weight of eating carbohydrates we might type "carbohydrates lead to weight gain" into the search bar. This can return biased results because of the "filter in" and "filter out" phenomenon. That is, you will most likely:

- filter in web pages that *do* talk about there being links between carbohydrates and weight gain, and
- filter out any that *do not* talk about or debunk such links.

This unhelpful searching can therefore reinforce our belief that there is a link! This is called *confirmation bias*, which happens when we go looking for information that will confirm a belief we already hold.

There are two steps you can take to change the way you gather and filter information from the internet.

Step 1: Use more balanced, neutral, and less biased search phrases to find out what you want to know. For example, instead of "carbohydrates lead to weight gain" you could search "the effects of carbohydrates".

Step 2: Look for ways of including alternative view points. You can do this by typing in mismatching statements. For example, "carbohydrates are unhealthy" and "carbohydrates are healthy".

Have a go and see what you notice...these strategies can lead to you coming up with some very different information!

Evaluating Information

Even when using helpful search strategies, not all of the information we find is accurate. Unfortunately, many people present information as fact when it may not be evidence-based. Often, people are not qualified to provide such information, and are just sharing an opinion they hold. For example, many titles do not require a formal qualification, registration with an official board, or training—anyone can call themselves a 'health and fitness expert' without having any expertise!

So how do we know what information is reliable? These questions can help us evaluate the credibility of information:

- 1) Does the author have a legitimate qualification in the area they're giving advice on? (e.g., GP, dietitian, psychologist, academic)
- 2) Is the author trying to sell you a product or service?
- 3) Is this information consistent with health information you have read from other reputable sources? (e.g. government guidelines, universities)
- 4) Is a date provided so that you can check that the information is up-to-date?
- 5) Does the author provide reliable evidence to back up their claims (e.g. several large research studies), or are they using personal stories and one-off studies?

One Size Does Not Fit All!

Dietary recommendations and advice are not the same for everyone. Different bodies, in different stages of recovery have very different needs. It is very important to remember that what "works" for one person, may not be what is best for you.

Seek a Second Opinion

When making substantial changes to something like your eating or exercise habits, it can be helpful to seek a second opinion. If after evaluating your dietary advice, you would still like to make changes, we recommend speaking to a GP or a dietitian, who can help you understand any benefits or drawbacks that may be relevant to you specifically. If you have an eating disorder it may be helpful to speak with somebody who has specific knowledge about eating disorders.

